

Project kickoff



Navigating Child Care at RAF Lakenheath

Between packing out your household goods, securing your no-fee passports, and figuring out how to drive on the left side of the road, figuring out your child care strategy should be at the top of your PCS to-do list.

At RAF Lakenheath, there are multiple child care options that require active planning. Whether you are Active Duty or a DoD Civilian, the tri-base area offers three distinct pathways to keep your little ones cared for: the Child Development Center (CDC), Family Child Care (FCC), and the Off-Base Subsidy Program (MCCYN).

Here is everything you need to know to secure a spot before your plane even touches down in the UK.

Child Care types

- Child Development Center (CDC)
- Family Child Care (FCC)
- Off-Base Subsidy Program (MCCYN)

On-Base: The Child Development Centers (CDC)

RAF Lakenheath boasts two main facilities—CDC East and CDC West—both accredited by the National Association for the Education of Young Children (NAEYC). They provide care for children ages 6 weeks to 5 years.

The Program

The CDC uses an active, purposeful play-driven curriculum designed to stimulate growth in language, mathematics, motor skills, creativity, and emotional health. Bonus for busy parents: they serve well-balanced, child-oriented meals daily, so you do not have to pack lunches.

Priority & The Waitlist

Because demand is high, wait times fluctuate between **0 to 12 months**. The Air Force manages the waitlist using a strict priority tier system based on your household status:

- **Priority A:** Single/Dual Military and Single DoD Civilians (with a Transportation Agreement).
- **Priority B:** Military or DoD Civilians with a working or student spouse.
- **Priority C:** Single Military (Non-Command Sponsored child) and DoD Civilians (without a Transportation Agreement).
- **Priority D:** Military or DoD Civilians with an unemployed spouse.
- **Priority E:** DoD Contractors.

Costs

Fees are subsidized by federal funds and are calculated using your Total Family Income (TFI). Be prepared to provide your latest Leave and Earnings Statement (LES) or civilian pay stubs. Per federal guidelines, your Basic Allowance for Housing (BAH) or local Living Quarters Allowance (LQA) equivalents, alongside your Basic Allowance for Subsistence (BAS), are added to your base earnings to determine your overall fee tier.

How to Register

Do not wait until you check into your squadron. You can place your child on the waitlist prior to your arrival by creating an account at [MilitaryChildCare.com](https://militarychildcare.com).

Contact Info

- **CDC East:** 011-44-1638-523285 | DSN: 314-226-3285
 - **CDC West:** 011-44-1638-525812 | DSN: 314-226-5812
 - *Hourly Care:* If you just need occasional drop-in care, hourly options are available. You must register locally using **AF Form 1181** and provide a copy of your child's up-to-date immunization records.
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Family Child Care (FCC)

If you prefer a smaller, home-like environment, the Family Child Care (FCC) program is an incredible alternative to the traditional CDC environment.

The Program

FCC providers are independent business owners operating out of government housing. They are fully licensed, background-checked, and regularly inspected by the base to ensure safety and quality standards.

Flexibility for Military Life

While the CDC operates on standard daytime hours, FCC providers frequently offer flexible schedules tailored to the mission. They care for children ranging from 2 weeks to 12 years old, and can accommodate:

- Full-time or part-time care
- Hourly or drop-in care
- Extended shift care, including nights, weekends, and swing shifts

Because you contract directly with the provider, you get personalized care that mirrors the CDC's developmental standards but fits an unconventional flightline schedule.

Contact Info

To get a list of currently licensed in-home providers, contact the **Family Child Care Office** at **01638-52-2170** or **DSN 226-2170**.

The Air Force Subsidy Program (MCCYN)

If the base CDCs are full, the Air Force does not leave you hanging. The Military Child Care in Your Neighborhood (MCCYN) program steps in to partially subsidise the cost of utilizing a local British nursery or off-base child care facility.

How it Works

The subsidy bridges the financial gap. It calculates what you *would* pay at the base CDC based on your TFI, and covers the difference up to a specified weekly cap. This ensures that high-cost local British nurseries remain affordable for families across all income brackets.

- **Currency Protection:** The subsidy is calculated in US Dollars, meaning your weekly parent fee will not fluctuate wildly with changing British Pound (£) exchange rates.
- **Provider Standards:** To protect your children, the program is strictly voluntary and limited to pre-approved British facilities that meet stringent DoD criteria (local UK licensing, background checks, and strict safety inspections).

Crucial Rules of Engagement

1. **Do Not Start Care Yet:** You must contact the base Community Child Care Coordinator first. They will ensure the local British facility completes the correct paperwork before forwarding it to the Air Force Family Child Care Subsidy Program for official approval. If you start care before receiving the green light, you will foot the entire bill yourself.
2. **Stay on the CDC Waitlist:** To remain eligible for the monthly off-base financial subsidy, you must keep your child's profile active on MilitaryChildCare.com.
3. **The CDC Offer Rule:** If a spot opens up at the base CDC and it is offered to you, you have a choice. You can move your child to the base, or you can choose to keep them at the off-base nursery. However, if you turn down the base CDC slot, your off-base subsidy terminates immediately, and you will be responsible for 100% of the civilian fees.

4. **Termination of Benefits:** The subsidy automatically stops if the active-duty member or DoD civilian separates from service, or if a non-working spouse fails to secure employment or full-time student status within 6 months.

Contact Info

- **Community Child Care Coordinator:** DSN: 226-2170 | Commercial: 01638-52-2170
 - **Cell Phone:** +44 7435 109566
 - **Email:** 48FSS.FSYF.AppleID@us.af.mil
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